

HTML Notes

1. Okay so what even is HTML?

HyperText Markup Language, that's what it stands for. First time I heard “markup language” I honestly thought it meant something to do with pricing, turns out no, it just means it's not a programming language at all. No logic, no math, nothing actually 'runs.' It just tells the browser what each piece of content is — this is a heading, this is a paragraph, this is a picture, whatever. That's it, that's the whole job. Every website I've ever opened, even the really slick modern-looking ones, has this sitting underneath it somewhere.

2. Why start here and not somewhere “cooler”

I get why it feels boring compared to CSS or JS, there's no colors, no animations, nothing flashy happening. But none of that other stuff has anything to work with if this part isn't there first. CSS is literally just styling THIS. JS is just adding behavior to THIS. So yeah, it's not the fun part, but it's the part everything else depends on, so might as well actually understand it properly instead of rushing past it.

3. The basic skeleton (every file starts like this)

tells the browser “this is HTML5”

everything lives inside this

title, meta info, links to CSS — not visible

everything the visitor actually sees

4. Rules I keep having to remind myself of

- Most tags open **and** close — `<p>text</p>` (this one's easy to forget the closing part of, ask me how I know)
- Some tags just don't close at all — `<img>`, `<br>`, `<hr>`, so don't go looking for a closing tag that isn't coming
- Tags can carry “attributes” — extra info in the opening tag, like `<a href="...">`
- You can put tags inside other tags (nesting), just close the inner one before the outer one or things break in weird ways
- Anything inside `<!-- -->` is a comment, browser ignores it completely, good for leaving myself little notes
- Everyone writes tag names lowercase, technically it doesn't have to be but do it anyway, it's just the convention

5. The “semantic” tags (fancy word, simple idea)

For a while I just used <div> for literally everything because it works, but apparently HTML5 added tags that actually say what a section IS instead of just being a generic box. Makes the code way more readable once you get used to it:

<header>	top of a page/section, usually logo or title
<nav>	the navigation menu / links
<main>	the core content, only one per page
<section>	a distinct chunk of related content
<article>	self-contained content, like a blog post
<aside>	sidebar / related content
<footer>	bottom of the page, contact info / copyright

6. Tags I actually use all the time, sorted so I stop scrolling around looking for them

TEXT & STRUCTURE

<h1–h6> headings, h1 = biggest / most important, h6 = smallest, don't use more than one h1 per page

<p> just a normal paragraph of text

 makes it bold, but it's supposed to mean the text is important, not just “look bold”

 italic, same deal, it's meant to signal emphasis not just style

 line break, use sparingly, mostly p tags handle spacing on their own

LINKS & MEDIA

<a> makes a clickable link, always needs href or it goes nowhere

 shows an image, needs src for the file path and alt in case it fails to load

GROUPING (my most used tags honestly)

<div> generic block, mainly for grouping stuff together to style/organize later

 same idea as div but inline, doesn't push to a new line

LISTS

<ul / ol> ul = bullet points, ol = numbered list

 each individual item inside either list

TABLES

<table> the container for the whole table

<tr> one row

<th / td> th = header cell (bold, top row usually), td = a normal cell

FORMS

<form> wraps everything that's part of the form

<input> the actual field, its type attribute decides if it's text/email/password/etc

<label> connects text to a field, keep forgetting this one but it matters for accessibility

<select / option> dropdown and its choices

<button> clickable button, obviously

7. Random stuff I learned the hard way

→ An unclosed tag can quietly break the whole rest of the page, learned this after way too much confused debugging

→ Don't skip alt text on images, it's not just a "nice to have," it actually matters

→ Indenting isn't required for it to work, but going back into un-indented code later is genuinely painful

→ HTML on its own will always look plain and boring, no colors, no layout — that's completely normal, styling isn't its job

→ Honestly the fastest way to actually learn this was just building small dumb pages instead of only reading about it